

My Claude Usage Strategy

A personalized model & effort guide

Profile: Student · Daily user · Focus areas: Career Prep/Resume, Learning/Studying, Coding, Research

Recommended Primary Model

Claude Sonnet 5 — set as your default model.

Why This Model Fits Me

As a student juggling coding, research, learning, and resume/career prep, you need one model that's strong across *all* of those without wasting effort. Sonnet 5 has been the default for Free and Pro claude.ai users since July 1, 2026, and for the first time the default is genuinely the right model for most professional work. It handles coding, writing, analysis, research, and complex problem-solving well — your entire activity list — and it's efficient with your rate limit, which matters since you use Claude daily.

When to Use Haiku

- Simple, straightforward questions with short answers
- Quick fact lookups, formatting fixes, quick rephrasing while studying
- Summarizing short notes/articles fast

⚠ **Caution:** Haiku's reliable knowledge cutoff is older (Feb 2025) than Sonnet 5 and Opus (Jan 2026) — avoid it for research needing recent information.

When to Use Sonnet

Your **daily driver**. Use by default for:

- All coding help (debugging, learning to code, project building)
- Resume writing, cover letters, interview prep
- Research synthesis, essay writing, study guides, concept explanations
- Document and spreadsheet creation

When to Use Opus

Save for genuinely hard moments — not daily use:

- A coding problem where you've tested with Sonnet and it struggled
- Long multi-step agentic work — e.g. a big multi-file capstone project
- Deep, multi-step research synthesis where accuracy really matters

Recommended Effort Level

Low

Fast lookups, definitions, quick grammar/formatting checks, simple study Q&A.

Standard (your everyday default)

The right balance for most work: daily coding help, study explanations, drafting resume bullet points, general research questions.

High

Tougher assignments: debugging a gnarly piece of code, understanding a genuinely hard concept, structuring a full research paper, serious interview prep.

Max

Rare — only for your hardest problems. Think: a major project deadline, a full capstone codebase, or a comprehensive research deep-dive.

My Personalized Claude Workflow

Task	Best Model	Best Effort	Reason
Debugging code / learning new syntax	Sonnet	Standard	Strong daily coding partner
Hard coding project / capstone	Opus	High	Needs deeper multi-step reasoning
Concept explanations / study help	Sonnet	Standard	Balances depth and speed for learning
Quick fact check / definition	Haiku	Low	Fast, cheap, no deep thinking needed
Resume & cover letter writing	Sonnet	Standard-High	Needs nuance and quality wording
Mock interview prep	Sonnet	High	Needs sharper reasoning and realistic feedback

Research paper synthesis	Sonnet	High	Needs to connect multiple sources accurately
Major thesis / deep research	Opus	High-Max	Highest accuracy for high-stakes work
Summarizing short notes	Haiku	Low	Simple, high-volume, low-stakes task

Biggest Mistakes I Should Avoid

- **Using Opus for everyday coding/study help** — wastes your rate limit for no gain, and is slower.
- **Using Haiku for anything needing current information** — its knowledge cutoff is older, risky for research.
- **Always leaving effort on Max "just in case"** — burns through your daily limit fast.
- **Not adjusting effort for hard problems** — tuning effort is often more useful than switching models entirely.
- **Skipping model checks before big deadlines** — test Sonnet first; only escalate to Opus if it genuinely struggles.

Final Recommendation

If you could use only **ONE model + ONE effort level**:

Claude Sonnet 5 at Standard effort

It covers coding, learning, research, and resume/career work well enough for nearly all daily student tasks, and it's efficient with your usage limit as a daily user. Bump to **High** only when you hit something genuinely tough (hard bug, big paper, mock interview) — that single adjustment covers 95% of what Opus would otherwise be needed for.